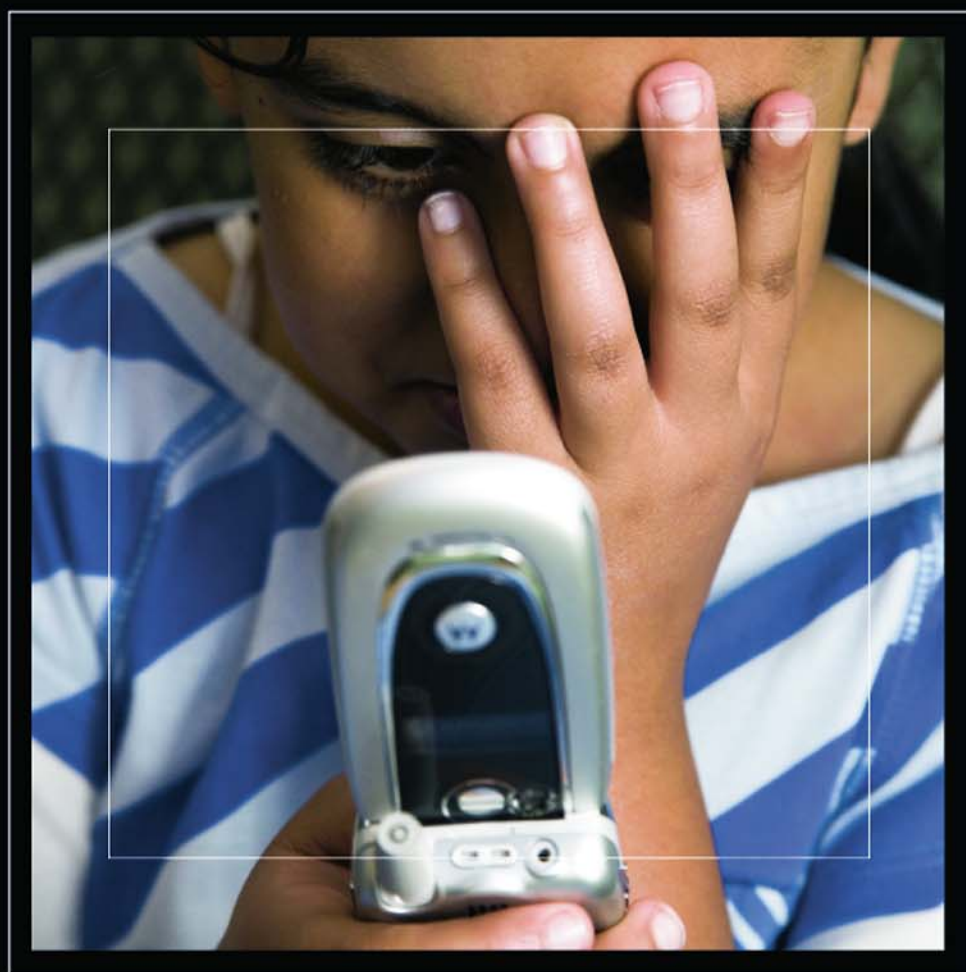


CYBER- BULLYING

Issues and solutions for the school,
the classroom and the home



SHAHEEN SHARIFF

Cyber-Bullying

'The first thing is, I love you Mom and Dad, but you didn't understand why I had to commit suicide. There was so much going on, and I tried to cope with it, but I couldn't take it anymore . . .' (Extract from the suicide note from Hamed Nastoh and used with the permission of his family.)

Shaheen Shariff's thought-provoking book alerts all educators and policy-makers to the rise of cyber-bullying internationally, and the dangers of implementing reactive responses to control it. This electronic form of bullying is difficult to monitor or supervise, often because it occurs outside the physical school setting and outside school hours, but as this ground-breaking book shows, home computers and personal mobile/cellular phones have provided children today with 'an arsenal of weapons for social cruelty'.

As teachers demand the banning of web sites such as YouTube, Facebook and MySpace, schools and governments introduce stricter legislation and filtering systems. Students on the other hand, challenge school suspensions and expulsions as infringing their rights to free expression and privacy, insisting schools have no supervision rights in cyberspace.

These emerging issues have created an urgent need for this powerful and practical book, which:

- is grounded in comprehensive scholarship
- addresses the policy-vacuum
- provides practical educational responses to cyber-bullying
- develops guidelines for educators and administrators regarding the extent of their obligations to prevent and reduce cyber-bullying
- highlights ways in which schools can network with parents, the justice system, technology providers and community organizations to provide support systems for victims (and perpetrators) of cyber-bullying.

Written by one of the few experts on the topic, *Cyber-Bullying* challenges reactionary school responses and encourages you to reconsider whether the culprits defined in this battle as kids and technologies are instead victims of a society in which the adults model intolerance and discrimination. The author peels away the layers chapter by chapter, to help you reconceptualize cyber-bullying to discover the educational potential of children and digital literacies.

Now teaching at McGill University, Montreal, **Shaheen Shariff** comes from a background in educational law and policy studies. Increasingly she is seen as the global expert on the topic of cyber-bullying.

Cyber-Bullying

Issues and solutions for the school,
the classroom and the home

Shaheen Shariff

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This book is for my family

Hanif, my pillar of strength

Farhana, you will heal and be healed . . .
always be happy

Zahir, my ever-present soul-mate

In memory of Hamed Nastoh and his plea to educate

Dear Mom and Dad:

The first thing is, I love you Mom and Dad, but you didn't understand why I had to commit suicide. There was so much going on, and I tried to cope with it, but I couldn't take it anymore . . .

It was horrible. Every day, I was teased and teased, everyone calling me gay, fag, queer, and I would always act like it didn't bug me . . .

But I was crying inside me. It hurt me so bad, because I wasn't gay. And when people said it, my own friends never backed me up. They just laughed. I would pray to God every night for every one to stop saying that.

I know that you are going to miss me and that you will never forgive me, but you will never understand. You weren't living my life. I hate myself for doing this to you. I really, really hate myself, but there is no other way out for me.

Sure, I could have taken a gun and shot everyone in the head . . . but what would the point be?

I know I left my room messy. You can clean it if you want, but please don't sell or throw anything away. Even though I won't be there, I still want that room. It has to be my room . . .

I love you Dad and Mom. Please, please tell the people at the school why I did this. I don't want somebody else to do what I have done.

Mom, after my death please, please go to schools and talk to kids that bullying and teasing has big consequences. And tell them to please stop crying. That's just my only wish and I hope people will miss me. Please visit my grave often, so I'm not lonely.

(Used with the permission of Nasimah Nastoh, Hamed's mother)

Contents

<i>List of illustrations</i>	xii
<i>Preface</i>	xiii
<i>Acknowledgements</i>	xviii
1 Cyberspace: battleground or opportunity?	1
<i>Introduction</i>	1
<i>Battles in cyberspace</i>	2
<i>Worthy weapons?</i>	3
<i>What drives this 'battle'?</i>	3
<i>Peer-to-peer cyber-bullying</i>	4
<i>Anti-authority cyber-expression</i>	4
<i>'Raveger, Raveger'</i>	5
2 Profile of traditional and cyber-bullying	10
<i>What is bullying?</i>	10
<i>The etymology of bullying</i>	12
<i>Bullying or teasing?</i>	13
<i>General characteristics</i>	15
<i>Perpetrators and targets</i>	17
<i>Types of bullying</i>	19
<i>Physical bullying</i>	19
<i>Psychological bullying</i>	22
<i>Changing roles</i>	24
<i>Effects of bullying</i>	25
<i>Bullying today</i>	27
<i>Definitions of cyber-bullying</i>	28
<i>Characteristics of cyber-bullying</i>	32
<i>Anonymity</i>	32
<i>An infinite audience</i>	33
<i>Prevalent sexual and homophobic harassment</i>	34

<i>Permanence of expression</i>	34
<i>MySpace, Facebook and YouTube</i>	34
<i>Online social communications tools</i>	35
<i>Online sexual discrimination</i>	38
<i>Female victims</i>	38
<i>Female perpetrators</i>	40
<i>Male targets and perpetrators</i>	40
<i>Intersecting forms of discrimination</i>	41
<i>The international context</i>	41

3 A transnational snapshot

43

<i>Introduction</i>	43
<i>Context and analysis</i>	47
<i>Japan</i>	48
<i>Technology use: computers</i>	48
<i>Technology use: mobile cellular phones</i>	49
<i>Cyber-bullying among Japanese peers</i>	50
<i>Cultural considerations</i>	51
<i>Ijime and netto-ijime</i>	51
<i>Gakko ura saito: mobile-bullying</i>	53
<i>Ijime-jisatsu (suicide linked to ijime)</i>	53
<i>South Korea</i>	54
<i>Singapore</i>	55
<i>China</i>	55
<i>Concerns about cyber-bullying</i>	56
<i>Chinese cases related to cyber-bullying</i>	56
<i>Thailand</i>	62
<i>India</i>	63
<i>United Kingdom</i>	65
<i>Access to the Internet</i>	67
<i>Nature of Internet use</i>	67
<i>Inequalities and the digital divide</i>	68
<i>Education, learning and literacy</i>	68
<i>Communication</i>	68
<i>Participation</i>	69
<i>Risks of online communication</i>	69
<i>Regulating the Internet at home</i>	69
<i>Happy slapping</i>	70
<i>United States</i>	70
<i>Bullying happens more often offline</i>	72
<i>Gender differences</i>	73
<i>The online rumour mill</i>	73
<i>Threats against older girls</i>	74
<i>Modified photographs</i>	74

	<i>Racial differences</i>	76
	<i>Why teens engage in cyber-bullying</i>	76
	<i>Homophobia</i>	77
	<i>Canada</i>	77
	<i>Adult perceptions</i>	80
	<i>Opinions about cyber-bullying</i>	80
	<i>Australia</i>	86
	<i>New Zealand</i>	88
	<i>Breaking news</i>	89
	<i>US controversy: Mrs Drew and Megan</i>	89
	<i>New law in Pakistan</i>	90
4	The role of gender: biological and environmental influences	90
	<i>Introduction</i>	90
	<i>Socialization in the home</i>	92
	<i>The biology of bullying</i>	92
	<i>Environmental influences</i>	95
	<i>Gender socialization in the home</i>	96
	<i>Female gender roles</i>	96
	<i>Male gender roles</i>	99
	<i>How media frames reality</i>	103
	<i>Media framing of gender roles</i>	105
	<i>Cyber-news on girls</i>	105
	<i>Helpless online girls</i>	106
	<i>She brought it on herself</i>	107
	<i>Authority figures</i>	107
	<i>Clueless parents</i>	107
	<i>Heroic policemen</i>	109
	<i>Civil liberties for perpetrators</i>	109
5	Controlling kids' spaces	112
	<i>Introduction</i>	112
	<i>Supervising kids' spaces</i>	113
	<i>Confusing and disengaging children</i>	114
	<i>Enter the digital divide</i>	116
	<i>Kids' perspectives – their own private space</i>	117
	<i>Adult mindsets and the digital disconnect</i>	124
	<i>Levelling the plane of authority and power</i>	126
	<i>Legal and policy responses: a few examples</i>	130
	<i>European Union</i>	131
	<i>Council of Europe</i>	131
	<i>Council of Europe draft convention on cyber crime</i>	131

<i>European Commission (EU): Europe's information society: public consultation on safer Internet and online technologies for children</i>	132
<i>Safer Internet plus programme</i>	132
<i>Legislation in France</i>	133
<i>British responses</i>	134
<i>Don't suffer in silence web site</i>	134
<i>Criminology perspectives</i>	139
<i>Deleting Online Predators Act (2006 – H.R.5319 – 'DOPA')</i>	140
<i>Educational use</i>	143
<i>Library support for online education</i>	145
<i>Canadian responses</i>	146
<i>Conclusion</i>	146

6 Stakeholder power 149

<i>Introduction</i>	149
<i>Knowledge control</i>	151
<i>Influential stakeholders</i>	154
<i>Teachers and their unions</i>	155
<i>Why the sudden urgency?</i>	160
<i>A wall of defence</i>	160
<i>School reputation or support of victims?</i>	161
<i>Tacit condoning or peer-to-peer bullying</i>	163
<i>Selection . . . or censorship?</i>	168
<i>Lost parenting opportunities</i>	170
<i>Confused messages: furious father</i>	170
<i>Confused messages: concerned mother</i>	171
<i>Parental prerogative in schools</i>	172
<i>Special interest groups</i>	176
<i>Government influence</i>	177
<i>School boards</i>	182
<i>Media as censor</i>	184
<i>Cyber-victims – good students who get caught</i>	185
<i>Cyber-criminals: police as hero</i>	187
<i>Media framing of global issues</i>	188
<i>Courts as censors</i>	189

7 Balancing free expression: privacy and safety in cyberspace 191

<i>Introduction</i>	191
<i>Legal frameworks</i>	194
<i>Tort law</i>	194
<i>Cyber-libel: Canadian context</i>	195

<i>Cyber-libel: American context</i>	203
<i>Negligence, supervision and malpractice</i>	205
<i>Tort law, supervision and risk</i>	209
<i>Constitutional law: freedom of expression versus safety and privacy</i>	211
<i>Constitutional considerations</i>	215
<i>Expression as ‘material and substantive disruption’</i>	216
<i>Expression as ‘disruption of basic educational mission’</i>	218
<i>Nexus: computers as school property</i>	219
<i>Student expression off-campus</i>	221
<i>Human and civil rights jurisprudence: school environment</i>	221
<i>Summary: legal standards for schools</i>	223

8 Harmonious solutions 226

<i>Introduction</i>	226
<i>Pragmatic and comprehensive solutions</i>	228
<i>Legal literacy</i>	229
<i>Practical solutions: online limitations</i>	231
<i>Building proficiency at home</i>	236
<i>Raising student awareness of censorship</i>	239
<i>Critical legal literacy model for teacher education</i>	240
<i>A concept map: positive school environments</i>	242
<i>Levelling stakeholder hierarchies of power</i>	244
<i>The stakeholder model</i>	245
<i>Poisoned environment</i>	245
<i>Step 1: Identify the stakeholders</i>	245
<i>Step 2: Validate their claims</i>	247
<i>Step 3: Critically weigh each claim against the others</i>	247
<i>School board claims</i>	247
<i>School administrator claims</i>	247
<i>Teacher claims</i>	249
<i>Parental claims</i>	252
<i>Media priorities</i>	253
<i>Step 4: Minimal impairment of rights</i>	254
<i>Conclusion</i>	255

<i>Notes</i>	259
<i>References</i>	265
<i>List of cases</i>	287
<i>Index</i>	289

Illustrations

Figures

3.1	What is the school's role?	81
3.2	What about rights?	82
6.1	Typical forms of cyber-bullying	156
6.2	School's position on cyber-bullying	157
6.3	Students harassing students	157
6.4	School policy	183
8.1	'Horns' of the dilemma	226
8.2	The bonded design model	236
8.3	Critical legal literacy model	241
8.4	Concept map incorporating critical legal literacy	244

Tables

3.1	A transnational snapshot of technology use and reported cyber-bullying	44
3.2	Country-specific considerations	46
3.3	Making private information public is the most common form of cyber-bullying	72
3.4	Online rumours tend to target girls	74
3.5	Do social networks facilitate cyber-bullying?	75
3.6	Experience of being cyber-bullied	78
3.7	Would I report it?	84
5.1	Some dimensions of variation between the mindsets	125
6.1	Teachers on experience of cyber-bullying	155
7.1	Applicable legal standards: emerging and established	224
8.1	Validating stakeholder claims	248

Box

6.1	Canadian Teachers' Federation communications technology concern resolution	159
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Preface

When I first developed the prospectus for this book, I had not envisioned that by the time I finished writing it, the issue of cyber-bullying would expand to such an extent. It is now at the forefront of educational policy agendas throughout the world. Moreover, the study of cyber-bullying is now, more than ever, a moving target. This made it difficult to stop adding new information to this book as it emerged on a daily basis. If I had continued to do that, I would never have finished writing.

Twelve months ago, even I could not have imagined that, in such a short time, cyber-bullying would evolve to become the polemic issue it is today, resulting in angry protests and petitions that demand forceful action by national teachers' unions and legislators. On one side of the controversy, teachers are petitioning school boards and unions to enforce student expulsions; and ban social networking web sites with a view to regain control of student respect for school authorities. The perception at national and international levels is that the Internet gives students too much power, allowing them to run rampant circles around their supervisors. To control this, some governments are investing millions of dollars into filtering technologies that restrict access to chat rooms and social networking sites that have, in some cases, been 'hacked' through by sixteen-year-olds within minutes! At the other extreme, some students, parents, librarians and civil libertarians insist that expulsions, suspensions, attempts to ban web sites, filters and blocking systems are futile. They argue that schools have no right to intervene in online expression because this infringes student rights to freedom of expression that takes place off school campuses and outside of school hours. They argue that zero-tolerance policies do not foster positive or respectful learning environments, but instead create poisoned and chilled environments that perpetuate cyber-bullying.

The media has characterized the issues as a 'battle', with cyberspace as its battleground. What is at the heart of this hotly debated controversy? What changed over the last year to reach such intensity? While academics and policy-makers were attempting to understand the phenomenon of cyber-bullying among school children (where pre-adolescents and teenagers harassed,

threatened, demeaned and bullied each other online), many teachers and school principals shrugged their shoulders and suggested this had little to do with them. The consensus was that because most cyber-bullying took place from home, on personal computers and cellphones, outside of school time. It was therefore a parental responsibility. As such, they argued it should be addressed in the home. Many teachers, as evidenced by studies presented in upcoming pages, knew little about the extent of cyber-bullying that took place among their students, or their own legal responsibilities to protect students from abuse by classmates.

What changed was the advent and sudden popularity of a range of online social networking sites among teenagers. These sites unwittingly opened the doors to student online discussions in which teachers and school officials became the (intended or unintended) focus of student conversations. While most students use such networks responsibly, young people in many countries began to demean and sometimes express deeply offensive comments about certain teachers, school officials, university and college professors. For example, Facebook.com, a web site initially launched by a Harvard student to encourage online social relationships among Ivy league university students, suddenly became popular among high school students because of its capacity to upload hundreds of photographs and textual postings and connect large groups of friends. At the same time, YouTube.com also garnered the attention of teenagers, who discovered they could post amateur videos online without objection.

In the UK, one form of peer cyber-bullying known as 'Happy Slapping' was already popular. This form of bullying involved groups of teens slapping and beating selected victims, filming these actions, and posting them online. Other forms of peer cyber-bullying included setting up web sites and bulletin boards containing photographs of a classmate, and inviting insults, demeaning sexual comments and ratings to be posted and viewed by an infinite cyber-audience. A third form of peer cyber-bullying involved filming or taking pictures of victims, modifying the photographs to depict sexually graphic images, uploading them online and inviting comments from global audiences. All these forms of cyber-bullying among young people were paid negligible attention by school authorities in general. Now that teachers and school officials have become the subjects or focus of discussion on some social networking sites and bulletin boards, the matter has come to a head. Comments about teachers are posted on the public 'walls' of Facebook participants in the same way that graffiti about teachers was written on school washroom walls by previous generations of students. The Internet however, has far greater public reach than washroom walls. Insinuations that some teachers are paedophiles combined with other sexual insults; criticism of their manner of dress, appearance, accent, hygiene, and teaching styles, can have detrimental psychological impact, ruin teacher reputations and cause significant embarrassment.

In the past week, as I typed and edited the closing chapters of this book, I was contacted by several local school administrators from public and private schools. Most seemed quite anxious for advice before the school year started up again. I also received calls from several upset parents. All of them complained that their schools and school boards did nothing last year to protect their children from bullying or cyber-bullying despite numerous pleas for help. They were afraid to send their children back to school.

A number of organizations are beginning to take steps to gain an improved understanding of the issues. The Canadian Teachers Federation has invited me to join a task force its officers have created in response to teachers' demands for action; the Ontario College of Teachers conducted an interview and released it at the same time as a new survey on teachers' experiences with cyber-bullying in that Canadian province; and the Quebec School Boards Association has invited my participation in a task force on cyber-bullying. The Lester B. Pearson School Board in Quebec, thanks to the efforts of Mrs Nancy Hain, has already implemented a task force and workshops for teachers.

Most requests for guidance were received just prior to the new Fall term before pupils return to school. They indicate that there is a policy and practice vacuum that creates anxiety, tension and deep dilemmas for parents, educational policy-makers, administrators and teachers. The issues that have emerged with increased use of technologies have turned the notion of education and its administration, as we traditionally knew it, on its ear. Although the organizations that contacted me are all Canadian, the preliminary findings from an international research project I launched last year, with colleagues in Japan, China, India, Australia, New Zealand, United States and the United Kingdom (www.cyberbullying.co.nr), disclose that each of these countries are experiencing similar issues relating to cyber-bullying. Therefore, in this book, I have attempted to highlight some of the emerging issues internationally; analyse cultural and contextual differences in the way that young people in different parts of the world are engaging online; and consider legal and policy responses that have emerged at the global levels to address cyber-bullying. Unfortunately, we are still in the very early stages of researching the phenomenon of cyber-bullying. Research in many parts of the world is just beginning to get underway. Consequently, there is not a significant amount of scholarly research available in many Asian countries, other than examples of cyber-bullying cases that have caused concern. There has been significantly more activity relating to the study of traditional bullying in the UK and North America. This has naturally led to research initiatives that also take into consideration cyber-bullying in Western schools, resulting in more scholarly examination of the subject. However, even this was largely limited to behavioural perspectives over the last decade. It is only recently that the issues are being studied from interdisciplinary and critical perspectives that take into account contextual and systemic influences on children when they engage in online activity.

Given this context, I believe that my book will be timely and valuable as a guide for educators, policy-makers, parents, the media, technology providers and indeed anyone with a stake in understanding the complexities of cyber-bullying. My goal is to help readers to reconceptualize the way they think about education, student citizenship, socially responsible discourse and discipline in a digitized world. I put particular emphasis on the need to *value* our children and look more carefully for their participation and potential as leaders to resolving the issues we confront today. I believe that given sufficient responsibility and respect, youngsters can work collaboratively with adults towards new and digitized forms of learning that will detract from a focus on negative use of online tools.

My methodology is to provide readers with a foundation that informs them about the profile of traditional and cyber-bullying; the biological and sociological influences on children's behaviour; the power hierarchies among stakeholders within school systems that ultimately control what children learn and express on and off-line, to help them appreciate why typical approaches to address traditional and cyber-bullying are seemingly sensible, but do not work.

I bring together in laymen's terms, notions of substantive law and critical educational pedagogies that show greater promise of grounding educational responses to cyber-bullying. I present simple stakeholder models and guidelines that can inform teacher education and professional development towards the development of non-arbitrary, ethical, educational and legally defensible policies.

We must remember that our generation developed and continues to introduce the online communications tools that create children's digital realities. They are growing up in a world that is simultaneously physical and virtual. Cyberspace is very much an integral aspect of their world. Moreover, my book explains why I believe that the discriminatory attitudes young people express through cyber-bullying are merely reflections of attitudes and hegemonies that permeate our societies, embedded within the very structures of our institutions. We often fail to recognize or acknowledge their existence. While the stated intent of our school mission statements talk about fostering 'inclusive and respectful school environments' there seems to be a disconnect in the actual implementation of those mission statements in many schools. The Internet has simply provided the wide open spaces that allow for society's attitudes of prejudice and disrespect to surface, opening up a Pandora's box of challenges.

Many young people cannot imagine a world without computers, cellular phones or text-messaging. These tools, despite their growing pains, present infinite opportunities for improved learning, and the development of global networks, friendships and connections that we could never have envisioned as children, let alone partake. It is these exciting and innovative opportunities that we must integrate into a reconceptualized approach to education, rather

than dwelling too heavily on the dark side of technologies. While it is of course important to address the forms of cyber-bullying that have emerged, I hope to show in this book, that if we contextualize what is taking place and revisit the way we control and administer children's learning and expression we will make greater strides in navigating the dilemmas of cyber-communication. We ought to learn and grow *with* our children in an age of digital literacies, and empower the future generation to become responsible and contributing citizens, both of the physical and virtual worlds of cyberspace. Ultimately, we need to trust them to become better global citizens than we have been. To do this, they must have our committed support.

Shaheen Shariff, Ph.D.
Faculty of Education,
McGill University

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To the Nastoh family, thank you for allowing me to publish your son's very personal letter. Nasimah, you have had enormous impact in educating people about the devastating consequences of bullying in any form.

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Cyberspace

Battleground or opportunity?

Teachers declare war on cyber-bullying!

(Brown, 2007)

School war against the bullies brings academic success!

(Asthana, 2007)

Prof raises alarm about cyber-bullying!

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Internet gives teenage bullies weapons to wound from afar!

(Harmon, 2004)

Introduction

Until very recently, the mention of the word 'cyber-bullying' conjured images in people's minds of a computer game with 'Star Wars-type' characters engaging in battle. It was difficult to convince people that this topic would attract much global attention and soon arrive at the forefront of public policy debates in education and parenting. That time has come. The issue of cyber-bullying often tops the agendas of government officials, educators, parents, civil libertarians and legal practitioners. The rapid advancement of cellular phones and Internet technologies has opened up new and infinite spaces that young people can explore with fewer restrictions. If we are to believe the above media headlines, ironically, the issue of cyber-bullying *has* become a battle of sorts in cyberspace. It appears that students, civil liberties advocates and some parents defend student rights to free expression in cyberspace, whereas educators, teachers' unions, other parents and government officials want to restrict them.

The purpose of this book is to introduce readers to the key issues that inform the heart of this debate or 'battle' and provide guidelines for schools, parents

and other influential stakeholders, to address the emerging policy vacuum. My book presents international profiles of traditional and cyber-bullying and draws attention to the tensions that arise as a result of intersecting power relationships among stakeholders, all of whom are significantly impacted by emerging forms of student online expression. My goal is to raise awareness of the key dilemmas that confront schools, students and their parents, with a view to encourage reconceptualization of cyber-bullying, towards the development of proactive, educational and legally defensible responses. In much the same way as a painter might take time out from painting to have his eyes checked and his lenses readjusted so that the images he paints on his canvas become less blurred, so, too, I invite readers to take time out to readjust their assumptions and perceptions relating to the issues and reconsider them from the unique perspectives ventured here. The Internet and digital literacies have become part of young people's lives, their social relationships and their learning. I hope that the approaches I present in this book will facilitate this learning in school and home environments, both physical and virtual, that are conducive to children's well-being, learning and development as civil minded and socially responsible, contributing citizens of a global society. Young people cannot contribute in positive ways if there is a battle raging all around them.

Battles in cyberspace

This battle is consistently reflected in the media headlines that now appear regularly, giving the impression that one is reading about a *Star Wars* episode in cyberspace, with the Internet as the starship and kids as alien enemies. Consider the following headlines: 'A gift from the devil: Worry about online activities' (Soloyon, 2005); 'Cyber-bullying: The Internet is the latest weapon in a bully's arsenal' (Leishman, 2002); 'Internet gives teenage bullies weapons to wound from afar' (Harmon, 2004); and 'Cyber-bullying blighting our lives' (*Reading Evening Post*, 2006). These examples are a drop in the ocean of headlines that proliferate in news reports, which have global reach through the Internet. Most reports are framed to highlight the dangers and not the potential of online communication, often describing online tools as 'weapons'.

The news reports, as their headlines suggest, focus less on *why* kids might be using online communications networks as weapons to wound than on the dangers of using them. If we look at the headlines more closely, we discover that there is also a separate 'battle' taking place. This other war uses a different genre of 'weapons', commonly known to adults as 'policies' and 'legislation'. Consider the following headlines: 'Teachers *declare war* on cyber-bullying' (Brown, 2007); 'School *war against the bullies* brings academic success' (Asthana, 2007); 'Regina bylaw to *target* cyber-bullies' (CBC News, 2006); 'Web giants like You Tube are being *urged to get tough* with the *cyber-bullies* that use their sites to make pupils' and teachers' lives a misery' (Goff, 2007). A school

Dean's article is entitled '*Foiling Cyberbullies in the New Wild West*' (Franek, 2006). (Emphasis has been added in all examples.)

It seems ironical that these sensational headlines create a fear of online technologies, but focus on 'fighting', 'curbing', 'controlling' and 'clamping-down' on the '*cyber-bullies*'. The headlines refer to children, teenagers and young adults who appear to be ensnared by evil technologies. It is even stranger that so many media reports sensationalize and indicate support for an adversarial approach by educators to control and manage young people's online expression.

Worthy weapons?

The 'weapons' being used in attempts to control cyber-bullying, consist of lobbying by teachers' unions, parents and school administrators who want their governments to implement laws and policies that censor social communication tools such as Facebook and YouTube from being accessed at schools. Some call for bans on cellular and mobile phones that have photographic and text-messaging capabilities. Others want to restrict computer use while children are at school; impose school board monitored firewalls; and enforce zero-tolerance policies that include suspensions and, in some cases expulsion, as deterrents to bullying (Education Act, R.S.O., 1990). In the southern United States, some governments have also declared cyber-bullying serious enough to come under the umbrella of 'homeland security' legislation (Shariff and Johnny, 2007b).

Two of the headlines at the start of this chapter, namely, 'Prof raises alarm about cyber-bullying' (Lampert, 2006) and 'Curb 'cyber-bullies' prof urges' (Bohn, 2006) refer to a public presentation that I gave at McGill University in February 2006. These national headlines took me by surprise the following day. My talk for educators had called for responses to cyber-bullying that are grounded in educational and non-arbitrary, proactive responses. I do not want to raise alarm bells but I certainly want to raise awareness. The last thing I wish to do is make people fearful. As I have discovered, the media does an adequate job of that.

What drives this 'battle'?

The media headlines discussed above do not clarify *what* we are fighting. If the *technology* is dangerous, then why are we clamping down on the '*cyber-bullies*' instead? In this book, I want to examine carefully the notion that violence can be controlled, banned, censored, fire-walled, managed or snuffed out in a contemporary and globalized world using violent or intolerant responses (zero-tolerance and suspensions). What do we seek to achieve as a society in our current responses to technology use among young people? Is there really an

‘enemy’? Do there have to be scapegoats, and does society attach unrealistic notions of danger to the Internet or to youngsters who engage in online teasing and torment of peers and authority figures? Can cyberspace be ‘controlled’, and, indeed, can the communications that take place using electronic tools and media be ‘managed’ or ‘supervised’?

There are two aspects to the issue of cyber-bullying that I plan to address in this book.

Peer-to-peer cyber-bullying

The first, which is less controversial, involves cyber-bullying among peers. Although this aspect of the issue has, in and of itself drawn a significant amount of media attention, there have been fewer vocal calls by educators for strong action. Cyber-bullying among students has been assumed to be an extension of traditional bullying that has nothing to do with school responsibilities because it generally takes place from home computers and personal cellphones. There is disagreement among parents and schools as to who is responsible for monitoring and preventing children and young people from bullying their peers online. As I will explain when I present the profiles of traditional and cyber-bullying, there is always a power differential when bullying takes place. In peer-to-peer bullying (physical or virtual), the power differential is at the level of young people, where a certain number of peers have a power advantage over their target(s).

Anti-authority cyber-expression

The second form of student expression, also commonly referred to as ‘cyber-bullying’, has recently attracted substantially more attention. There have been stronger calls for action from school and government officials, teachers and teachers’ unions, because this form of cyber-bullying involves postings by students on social networking sites. Although most young people use social networking sites responsibly, a number of students have used them to demean and put down their teachers or school administrators, joke about them, modify photographs and invite insults and comments by students. There is disagreement among students (supported by civil libertarians and some parents) and school authorities as to whether this form of online expression by students constitutes ‘cyber-bullying’. While the upcoming chapters engage in analysis of this debate, I have included it in this book as a form of cyber-bullying because it has attracted so much attention and concern from educators and policymakers. The power differential involved in this form of student online communication is reversed. The ‘victims’ of such expression are teachers, school principles and college and university professors (authority figures), who are disempowered because they have little control over who sees the online

comments about them. Because the jury is still out as to whether this form of student expression constitutes cyber-'bullying', I also refer to it as 'anti-authority cyber-expression' or 'anti-authority online expression'.

'Raveger, Raveger'

My first experience with cyber-bullying began with an email from 'Raveger, Raveger [sic]'. The email was sent to our daughter Selina (pseudonym), when she was about 15, in Grade 11 at a high school in British Columbia, Canada. We came home one afternoon and found her pale and frightened, which was unusual for this normally feisty teenager. She handed us a printout of the email which read:

You don't know me . . .
 But I know you . . .
 I've been watching you at school . . .
 And if you don't want to die . . . I'd sleep with one eye open
 Down on your knees, bitch!
 Raveger, Raveger

(Shariff, 2001)

As a parent, I was concerned about Selina's safety. Was this a paedophile? Was it an adult at school? If a student was involved, did he know her walking route home from school? The reference to watching her at school brought the threat into the realm of the physical school environment, despite the fact that it was sent over the weekend from a home computer. School police liaison officers were unsuccessful in tracing the email, and our efforts to trace the source of the email through the ISP provider met a brick wall. At first there was no response to our calls and emails. When eventually contacted, an ISP manager explained that he could not shut down the email source to protect the client's free expression rights.

A male classmate eventually confessed that he and three others had sent the email from his home computer. Once the boy learned police were involved, he owned up to being coerced by the primary instigator, Mike (pseudonym). Apparently Mike had wanted to date Selina, who had refused his advances, and he sought revenge through email. Though school administrators were provided with the perpetrators' names, the boys were not disciplined because the email was not sent from school. Consequently, the harassment continued at school, where Selina was stalked and verbally bullied by the boys, who continued to go by the name of 'Raveger'. During one classroom project, the boys insisted on having Selina join their group. The teacher saw no problem with that, becoming impatient at Selina's reluctance to join them. Selina burst into tears. Once the problem was explained, the teacher confessed to having no prior knowledge of the incident, despite the Principal's commitment

to us that he would inform all Selina's teachers about the threats the four boys had perpetrated.

Little did the 'Raveger' boys know how often the words contained in their email would be repeated in educational contexts – at conference presentations, in published journal articles and book chapters, in media reports (Shariff and Strong-Wilson, 2005) and, now, in the first chapter of a book on cyber-bullying. 'Raveger' helped me launch a career dedicated in large part to researching and addressing the complex issues of student communication in cyberspace, the spill-over effect in physical space, and the blurred boundaries of student safety, privacy and free expression. More importantly, it helped me launch research into the extent of school responsibilities and those of parents, policymakers and law enforcement agents to intervene when school-mates engage in bullying outside school hours, on home computers or personal cellphones. Although this email was sent eight years ago, the issues it raised continue to challenge parents, school administrators and teachers worldwide, as technology use among pre-teens and adolescents flourishes. Ravager sets the stage for discussion of some key dilemmas that have surfaced with increased proliferation of new technologies among young people, and that continue to become significantly more complex as innovative social communication tools such as Facebook, MySpace, YouTube, Bebo, LinkdIn, Orkut and rapidly advancing cellphone technologies become established as contemporary modes of communication among the younger generation.

I believe it is important to provide readers with a sense of the broader societal context, which highlights the range of stakeholder influences such as the power of the media, government officials, school boards, school administrators, technology corporations, teachers and parents in shaping how we conceptualize, perceive and respond to technology and digital literacies. We ought to critically question whether we should be controlling to such a great extent what children learn in the home, at school and online. Alternatively, we need to consider how we can empower them, through engaging educational endeavours that develop respect and trust and enable informed and thoughtful decisions when they use technologies. I believe that adult mindsets that emphasize control of behaviour over mentorship and guidance result in ineffective policies and practices. These, in turn, bring out the forms of expression young people adopt to assert their developing identities, sense of space, privacy and security. It becomes a vicious cycle because our responses to children's actions and expressions online determine the extent to which they are empowered to take responsibility and leadership in their own growth, learning and social interactions, or whether they decide to break rules, hack through firewalls and search for independent spaces where adults cannot intervene. I suggest that the way in which online conversations and dialogues are defined, understood and responded to may also shape children's actions and reactions in a particular space and time, depending on environmental influences, past experiences

and biological triggers. Electronic space can be perceived as complicating the issues. Alternatively, it can be viewed as providing opportunities that open up young people's worlds. The mindset with which we approach technologies makes all the difference (boyd and Jenkins, 2006; Lankshear and Knobel, 2005). Although rules have their place in schools, officials who enforce those rules might want to apply some flexibility in certain contexts. For people who do not have a lot of experience with technologies, inflexible rules can cause considerable problems. Consider the following situation that almost cost an inexperienced substitute teacher her freedom.

In a controversial case involving Julie Amero, an American substitute teacher in Connecticut, Ms Amero was charged and convicted of accessing pornography on a classroom computer and allowing students to view it. Students had previously accessed a pornographic site and triggered a virus that kept bringing up pornographic pop-up screens, much to their amusement.

Amero maintained, with the support of academics and technology experts (Willard, 2007), that she was innocent and did not purposely access the porn site. She tried to explain that she simply switched on the classroom computer, and a pop-up screen for a pornography web site repeatedly surfaced through a 'mousetrap' trigger. According to Willard, this trigger is caused by 'malware' – a virus that lurks in the background and is designed to kick in when certain pornography sites are accessed either purposely or by mistake. Julie argued that the children could have accessed the web site that set off the trigger. In some schools, teachers are not allowed to turn off computers. Therefore Julie, trying to obey school rules, turned the screen away from their view and went to seek help. Regardless of the rules, perhaps a more experienced teacher would have turned off the computer to get rid of the trigger and then sought help. As a result of leaving the classroom with the pornographic site on the computer screen, some of the students viewed the web site, and she was subsequently charged. After six appeals and enormous public outcry, Ms Amero was acquitted and released from a sentence that would have committed her to forty years in jail – the penalty under Connecticut's S. 53–21 of the General Penal Code on Risk of Injury to a Minor.

In this situation, the school rules disallowing teachers from turning off the computer exacerbated the problem. This is why my objectives in this book include a review of the emerging complexities of cyber-bullying for teachers, schools, parents and policymakers generally. I want to bring a more human element into examination of some of the policy, rule-making and definitional challenges related to cyber-bullying and use of technologies. To that end, I will highlight the range of influences and stakeholders that can impact our understanding and *response* to the kinds of activity that students are beginning to engage in online. With each chapter, I peel away the layers of complexity to develop legal and educational guidelines that culminate in pragmatic but practical solutions in Chapter 8. Although these solutions do

not, by design, include any check-lists or rubrics, I believe they show greater promise of helping stakeholders navigate the challenges of student expression in cyberspace.

My analysis in this book brings a particular focus on the fostering of school environments (physical and virtual) that should be inclusive and empowering and support the education of children growing up in an increasingly wired world. I hope that the concerns I raise throughout this book, and the critically informed pedagogical approaches that I advocate at the end of the book, will raise awareness that bullying has always been complex. Technologies have simply brought these complexities into new spaces. I argue that the root causes or motivators for this type of online communication have not changed, and that technologies have provided new spaces in which information can be exchanged at far greater speeds for infinite audiences.

Hence, it is now more important than ever to adopt well-informed, educational, non-arbitrary, ethical and legally defensible policies and responses, no matter how upset we become with the content and challenges to authority contained in young people's online expressions. This book explains some of the tensions between balancing free expression, privacy, safety and supervision as student expression moves with fluidity between the boundaries of physical school settings and virtual spaces. I reiterate that, although I do not bring a 'to-do list', 'blue-print' or 'rubric' that parents and educators can follow to reduce cyber-bullying, I can certainly facilitate an appreciation of the nature of traditional bullying and cyber-bullying and draw attention to the gaps and root systemic considerations that are often overlooked when adults respond in anger and frustration.

As my experience with 'Raveger' discloses, I am a parent and educator who has experienced cyber-bullying and found the legal tensions fascinating to study. In the process I have dug deeper into the root causes of bullying and cyber-bullying and have discovered the need for a shift in the way we frame cyber-bullying, and conceptualize the policy development and practise dilemmas to address it. Even though rapidly emerging technologies make the study of cyber-bullying difficult because it is a moving target, I maintain that we are dealing with issues that have plagued social interaction among humankind for hundreds of years. Power hierarchies still exist that sustain and perpetuate discrimination and systemic oppression, grounded in racism, sexism, homophobia and ableism, which marginalize some people more than others. We cannot address a complex issue such as cyber-bullying without taking into account stakeholders' political agendas and parental prerogatives that influence what schools teach and what students learn. It is these issues that are rearing their heads through cyber-bullying at an increasingly rapid and infinite pace given the capabilities of new technologies. The underlying attitudes and motivations are not new. They are the same as they have always been. It is those aspects of bullying and cyber-bullying that we need to address through improved *education* – not control and censorship.

Before we turn to these issues, I would like to introduce readers to a general understanding of the nature of traditional bullying, its forms and profile and the conditions under which it occurs, as it has been studied within the paradigms of developmental psychology and sociology. The profiles of traditional and cyber-bullying that I present in Chapter 2 will establish that I appreciate the devastating impact of bullying and cyber-bullying that has tragically taken the lives of many young people through suicide or even murder. I have researched the subject sufficiently to understand the deep and lasting psychological consequences of bullying and cyber-bullying on children and adults who are victimized, especially at the hands of large groups of peers or unknown individuals on the Internet. And although I fully support a need for some form of consequences for those who engage in cyber-bullying, I contend that we place too much emphasis on discipline and punishment after the fact. I would like us to think about long-term proactive responses that might not have immediate impact, but over time should make their mark more permanently.

Background on traditional bullying is important because it lays the foundation for an improved understanding of emerging profiles of cyber-bullying. Chapter 3 presents a transnational snapshot of how cyber-bullying is emerging and being perceived in various countries with emerging technology use. In Chapter 4 I discuss the biological and socializing influences that greatly influence young people's propensity to engage in bullying, particularly from the perspective of gender differences. Chapter 5 then looks at how adults supervise and control kids' spaces, from home and playground spaces, to policy and legislation. Chapter 6 looks at the power hierarchies among the various stakeholders that influence what children learn and how they in turn express themselves on- and off-line. Chapter 7 addresses the debate on student free expression and supervision by looking at a range of judicial decisions under tort law, human rights and constitutional laws to culminate in a set of reasonable standards that can guide educators on their responsibilities. Finally, Chapter 8 considers pragmatic and practical solutions on how we might meet those legal responsibilities but, more importantly, engage children through educational endeavours that incorporate digital literacies and a critical pedagogical perspective that guides us to empower students and teachers through a collaborative and cohesive dialogue. These guidelines show greater promise of addressing the 'horns of the dilemma' of cyber-bullying than do the 'weapons' and 'battles' that are so enthusiastically endorsed in current conceptions and approaches to cyber-bullying.

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